



# Malaysia

Malaysia stretches 1240 miles (2000 km) across southeast Asia from the Malay peninsula to Sabah in eastern Borneo. Federated in 1963, it included Singapore for two years.



## GEOGRAPHY

The Malay Peninsula has central mountains, an eastern coastal belt, and fertile western plains. Swampy coastal plains rise to mountains on Borneo.



## CLIMATE

Warm equatorial. Rainfall always heavy, but with distinct rainy seasons.



**INSIGHT:** Malaysia is southeast Asia's major tourist destination, with over 20 million visitors a year



2000m/6562ft  
1000m/3281ft  
500m/1640ft  
200m/656ft  
Sea Level



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The key distinction is between Malays (Bumiputras, literally “sons of the soil”) and the Chinese, who traditionally controlled most economic activity. Since the 1970s, Malays have been favored for education and jobs, in order to address this imbalance.



## THE ECONOMY

Successful industrial base include manufacturing and heavy industry. Tourism is a major earner. Leading producer of palm oil, tin, and tropical hardwoods.

## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Federation of Malaysia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1963

**CAPITAL:** Kuala Lumpur and Putrajaya

**POPULATION:** 27.5 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 127,316 sq. miles  
(329,750 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 217 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Bahasa Malaysia\*, Malay, Chinese, Tamil, English

**RELIGIONS:** Muslim 53%, Buddhist 19%, Chinese faiths 12%, other 9%, Christian 7%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Malay 50%, Chinese 25%, indigenous tribes 11%, other 14%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Ringgit = 100 sen